

That was the phrase everyone was enamored with: “hard to get into.” It said that you were “good enough to get in” and “good enough to actually go.” That could mean you had a scholarship because you were smart or that your parents were smart enough to figure out a way for you to go (student loans, second mortgages, witchcraft).

Every day I looked at that bulletin board to see what kind of person was going out of state and what kind of person was staying in state. It became about more than just college, though. I wrapped my entire mental health and sense of self-worth up with getting into and going to a school outside Florida.

It was a financial soap opera. Years later, when I asked my parents why they allowed me to take out huge student loans to go out of state for college when I could have gone to UF for essentially nothing, they argued that I *needed* to leave Florida. But they weren’t being financially realistic. They were, like me and like many other people awaiting college acceptances, acting solely on emotion.

I asked my mom what would have happened had she and my dad said something like, “You need to be realistic about this. You are going to UF. End of discussion.” My mom looked appalled at the suggestion: “It was worth every penny for your mental health and for your happiness.” Right. But plenty of people probably “need” to get out of their hometowns and can’t afford to. It wasn’t practical, I said.

“Okay, so it wasn’t practical,” she replied. Case closed.

My environment at the time was, admittedly, not ideal. My dad was drinking heavily. I was a closeted bisexual in a group of friends who routinely used the word *lesbian* as a pejorative. I don’t think anyone thought I was queer, but I stuck out like a sore thumb in a way people couldn’t place and didn’t like. All I ever talked about in my diary was getting out of Florida and how if I couldn’t, I’d kill myself.

This is not a lighthearted joke about suicide. It was a serious consideration. I’d first thought about killing myself in the fourth grade by throwing myself down the stairs in my elementary school. I’d spent most of high school self-harming with a razor blade, and though that’s not necessarily a precursor to suicide, it wasn’t great. I didn’t know how much longer I could hide my sexuality without dire, perhaps fatal, consequences.